THE RESUMPTION OF ANGLO-BURMESE RELATIONS

Fearful of a Burmese-French alliance, the British decided to resume relations with Burma. The governor-general in India, Sir John Shore, dispatched envoy Captain Michael Symes to Ava, the capital of Burma in 1795. Symes was followed by Captain Hiram Cox in the fall of 1796. Tensions mounted as relations deteriorated when Burmese forces crossed the frontier from the Burmese province of Arakan to the British province of Bengal in pursuit of fleeing Arakanese rebels and refugees in 1799. Protracted negotiations between the Governor-General of India Marquis Wellesley and King Bodawpaya between June 1799 and June 1800 averted further conflict but failed to resolve either the Bengal-Arakan border issue or the repatriation of Arakanese refugees. Wellesley then dispatched a small British contingent to the Bengal-Arakan border and sent Symes to Burma to negotiate a full settlement.

Early in 1802, the Burmese governor of Arakan demanded the expulsion of all Arakanese refugees from Chittagong and threatened the invasion of British-held territory. Symes reached an agreement with King Bodawpaya in which the Burmese agreed not to make any more demands, threats, or incursions into the British province of Bengal but the frontier between Arakan and Bengal was never officially demarcated. This issue would later contribute to the outbreak of the first Anglo-Burmese war.

Anglo-Burmese relations were again tested in 1811 when Arakanese rebel leader Chin Byan led a rebel army across the border and attacked and defeated a Burmese garrison, eventually capturing the city of Mrohaung. Following his victory, Chin Byan extended an offer to the governor-general of India to rule Arakan under British suzerainty. While the offer was rejected by the British, the Burmese suspected the East India Company of secretly aiding and abetting Chin Byan as his bases were located well within company territory and British troops had prevented the Burmese from pursuing Chin Byan across the Naaf River boundary on the northern frontier. Eventually the Burmese crushed the rebellion, forcing Chin Byan and his rebel army to flee to the relative safety of Chittagong in British Bengal. Burmese forces again crossed the border in pursuit of Chin Byan, who managed to elude capture. The pattern of attack, followed by a tactical withdrawal across the frontier and rearmament on British-held territory